

Fulham 0-1 Manchester United

A measured read of the match -- from tracking data, not from a highlights reel

Craven Cottage, 26 January 2025, second half. Manchester United under Ruben Amorim. Source: football-synthesizer tracking pipeline, match id fulham_manutd.

This is not a highlights package. It is every passage of the second half that runs at least 18 seconds and clears our tracking gate, in order. Six passages. 122 seconds of measurement out of a 1,852-second half.

Craven Cottage, second half. Manchester United won it 1-0. Our system does not watch the game like a fan does. It watches the parts of the game where the camera, the tracker, and the pitch geometry all agree on where every player stands. That is a smaller slice of the match than you would think, and this report tells you exactly how small, and what it saw inside that slice.

This match carries the **highest post-link ball coverage in our whole twelve-match corpus**: 0.561 of sampled frames, against a corpus median of 0.465. If any match in our library was going to give a clean tactical read, it is this one.

Sources. results/tactical_clips/fulham_manutd_h2_islands.csv; results/MANUTD_IDENTITY_PROFILE.md Per-match evidence table; demo/showcase.html section d.

What we measured, passage by passage

Six passages pass our quality gate in the second half: at least 85% of expected frames with trusted geometry, at least 12 tracked players a frame, at least 60% ball coverage, both teams on screen.

Table 1. The six gate-passing passages, second half

Clock	Length	Players/frame	Ball coverage	Frame coverage	Both teams on screen
06:12	18s	13.3	95.6%	89%	83.5%
10:36	18s	14.8	93.4%	89%	83.5%
16:36	28s	14.7	92.9%	85.1%	79.4%
18:20	20s	12.3	99.0%	86.1%	81.2%
29:21	20s	17.3	75.2%	88.1%	88.1%
36:46	18s	13.4	94.5%	85.7%	76.9%

10:36 -- United escape their own box

United play out from their own goal line and never leave the touchline. The ball travels from 3 m to 24 m up the pitch, and from $y = 3$ m to $y = 2$ m across it: two metres of movement on a 68-metre-wide pitch, hugging the whitewash the whole way. United hold 96% of the possession frames in this passage. The only player our identity layer is confident enough to name is Joshua Zirkzee. This is not build-up play. It is an escape.

18:20 -- Fulham do the thing that fills a highlight reel and no scoresheet

Fulham hold 94% of the ball here. Calvin Bassey is the one name our identity gate allows onto the board. The ball swings the full width of the pitch, from $y = 61$ m to $y = 1$ m, reaching 64 m of advancement at its furthest point before the passage ends at 30 m -- nineteen metres *backwards* from where it started, in front of a defensive block our detector reads as low. Fulham have the ball. They are not going anywhere with it.

29:21 -- the half's only passage with a pulse

This is the densest passage of the half: 17.3 tracked players a frame, both teams on screen 88% of the time, the ball contested, neither side settling on it, the defensive line pushed up to a high read. Twenty-four seconds after this passage ends, our goal detector fires the only peak it produces in the entire match: score 0.847, second half, clock 30:05. The official record for this fixture shows exactly one goal, second half, to Manchester United.

The goal happens 24 seconds after our last measurable passage

We do not show you the goal. The moment the ball goes in, the broadcast cuts to the celebration, and every one of those cuts destroys the pitch geometry our measurement depends on. Our gate refuses the passage, and the clip jumps straight to a card instead.

We tested this on the whole corpus before accepting it as fixed, not just for this match. We took every goal peak our detector produces -- 30 peaks across 10 matches -- and scored the best window of 120, 90, 60 and 30 seconds ending at each one against our quality gate. **112 windows scored. Zero cleared the gate.** All 112 failed on the same clause: pitch geometry, never players or ball. The best two-minute window at any goal in the whole corpus reaches 50.9% frame coverage against a required 85%.

The reason is not a weakness in our tracker. It is what a broadcast is. A goal is immediately followed by a replay, a close-up of the scorer, the bench, the crowd -- and every one of those cuts breaks the pitch geometry the measurement rests on. Goals are the least measurable moments in a football broadcast. That is an inconvenient thing to learn while building a demo, and a useful thing to know if you are buying one.

Sources. results/tactical_clips/fulham_manutd_h2_islands.csv;
results/action_spotting_probe/fulham_manutd/summary.json (peak 0.847, h2 30:05);
results/tactical_clips/goal_window_scan.csv (112-row scan); demo/showcase.html section d. Note: fulham_manutd's single peak agrees with the official record on half and count, and 0.847 sits inside the 0.75-0.96 band every one of our thirteen validated true goals occupied -- but this match was not itself one of the six goal-validated matches, so we call it a peak, not a certified goal.

What the match looked like, in the round

Two more numbers from our full identity profile of this fixture, away leg, Amorim in charge:

Table 2. Match-level tracking summary

Metric	Value
Post-link ball coverage	0.561 (highest of 12 matches)
United defensive block line	27.0 m from own goal
Block front-to-back spread	6.56 m
United ball samples tracked	2,456
Clean attacking-direction votes	4 of 11 chunks

The block-line reading (27.0 m) sits inside United's twelve-match range for the season (20.8 m to 37.4 m), closer to the low end -- consistent with a team that, per Table 1's 10:36 passage, spent time defending very deep in their own third. We flag the "4 of 11" direction-vote figure honestly: it means the left/right framing we use to build the passage descriptions above rests on a minority of this match's video chunks giving a clean read, so treat the lateral detail (which flank, which channel) as the softer half of this report.

We do not report possession share or territory percentage for the whole match. Our ball layer only produces a reliable number inside a passage that clears the quality gate (Table 1); it does not produce a trustworthy whole-match possession split, because the broadcast's own camera choices bias which parts of the game we can see. Rather than compute a number we cannot stand behind, we report the six passages instead and let their per-passage possession share speak for the parts of the match we can actually measure.

Sources. results/MANUTD_IDENTITY_PROFILE.md Per-match evidence table (fulham_manutd row); results/MANUTD_IDENTITY_PROFILE.md section 3 (block-line range).

What we refuse to say, and why

No per-player statistics

We will not tell you how many passes Bruno Fernandes made, or rank any player's involvement in this match. Across our identity-tracked matches, only 1.0-4.2% of United's attributed passes carry a player's name -- two to five named passes a match. On 90 hand-labelled moments, the precision of naming the player on the ball is 0.35 to 0.40. A rebuilt, more constrained version of the naming logic did not beat that number. Any per-player total we could show you would be built on evidence that is right barely more often than a coin flip.

No calibrated uncertainty regions

Our tracking clips draw a shaded region around players we cannot currently see, showing where a model predicts they probably stand. Those regions were designed to be calibrated: the shaded 50% region should contain the true player 50% of the time, the 90% region 90% of the time. On real broadcast footage they do not. Measured against 4,900 real player re-appearances across four matches, the regions cover the true position 21.2% of the time when they claim 50%, and 55.4% of the time when they claim 90%. Every one of 14 testable buckets fails. We publish the measured numbers on every frame instead of the claimed ones.

Both refusals above are measurements, not caution for its own sake. We built each capability, tested it against real evidence, and it did not clear the bar we set for it. That is the honest output for this match, exactly as it would be for any match in this corpus.

Sources. results/PLAYER_ANALYSIS_v2.md; results/CARRIER_CONSTRAINED_v2.md; results/CALIBRATION_REPLICATION.md; knowledge/claims.json ident-008, b4-015.